

SportRoots

5 Drills for a Better First Touch

A free starter pack for soccer parents and coaches

Five proven first-touch drills you can run tonight
with just a ball and a little space.

Free Beta-Reader Edition

Why first touch?

First touch is the skill that decides everything else. A player who controls the ball cleanly has time; a player who doesn't is always rushing. These five drills build that control — most need only a ball and a small patch of space, and each takes about ten minutes.

How to use this pack

Set up one drill per session. Demonstrate it once, let your player try it, and use the coaching cue out loud. End every drill on a success — lower the difficulty before frustration sets in.

Drill 1 — Foundations (tic-tocs)

Setup: Ball at your player's feet, no cones needed.

How: Alternating touches with the inside of each foot, keeping the ball between the feet — like a tiny, fast shuffle. Count consecutive touches.

***Coaching cue:** “Little touches, ball stays close — like it's on a string.”*

Easier: Bigger touches, slower rhythm. **Harder:** Add a turn every 20 touches.

Drill 2 — Wall passes

Setup: Any wall or rebounder, player 5–8 yards away.

How: Pass against the wall and control the return with one touch, then pass again. Two-touch rhythm: control, pass.

***Coaching cue:** “Cushion it — soft foot on the way in, firm foot on the way out.”*

Easier: Let the ball come to a full stop before passing back. **Harder:** One-touch returns.

Drill 3 — Juggle ladder

Setup: Open space, one ball.

How: Start with thigh catches — drop the ball onto the thigh and catch it. Then thigh-to-foot. Then foot-to-foot. Build the ladder one rung at a time over sessions.

***Coaching cue:** “Relax the ankle — meet the ball, don't kick at it.”*

Easier: Allow one bounce between touches. **Harder:** Alternate feet every touch.

Drill 4 — First-touch gates

Setup: Two cones 3 yards apart (a “gate”), player 10 yards away with the ball.

How: Toss or pass the ball to your player; their first touch must take the ball *through* the gate to one side. The touch itself does the turning.

***Coaching cue:** “Touch it where you want to go, not where it came from.”*

Easier: Widen the gate. **Harder:** Call out “left” or “right” as the ball travels.

Drill 5 — Partner cushion

Setup: You and your player, 8–10 yards apart, one ball.

How: Throw or chip the ball to your player at different heights — feet, thighs, chest. They cushion it down and play it back. Vary the height every few reps.

***Coaching cue:** “Give with the ball — pull back as it arrives.”*

Easier: Underhand tosses to the feet only. **Harder:** Driven balls and chest control.

Making it stick (for parents)

Two short sessions a week beats one long one. Ten focused minutes, twice a week, will show in your player's game within a month. Praise the attempt, not just the outcome — “great idea taking it to the left” builds a braver player than “nice touch” alone.

Keep going

These five drills are a starting point. SportRoots' full library has coach-built video programs for soccer, volleyball, and multi-sport athletes ages 6–18 — organized by sport, age, and skill level, with most sessions running 10–25 minutes at home. Start with a free trial and see the difference structured practice makes.

Explore SportRoots: sportroots.polsia.app

Thank you!

Thanks for being a SportRoots beta reader. If these drills helped your player, the best thank-you is telling another soccer parent about them — and if you have feedback, I read every reply.

— Bill Morton, SportRoots